additional pressure point on the government. This was evident during the NSG's consideration of the Indo–US nuclear deal.

If a negotiation fails, perception management becomes all the more important for the Chinese. Their preference is for both sides to issue anodyne statements that suggest there is a possibility of future resolution. If a negotiation is unsuccessful, it is preferable for the Indian side to make that clear through public statements rather than paper them over, as the absence of acrimony in public is usually viewed as a Chinese gain. Acrimony in public unsettles them. In fact, China's public image is a source of its vulnerability. The Chinese want to be seen as the beautiful swan gliding on the placid surface of a lake in sylvan surroundings. Below the surface, their feet are churning away and roiling the waters for the other creatures below the surface, but this remains unseen. In this way, if the other party alleges that the Chinese are the trouble-making party, this is not apparent to anybody else and hence there are no takers for this. If, however, the fish and other aquatic inhabitants of the lake agitatedly jump out of the water in response to the furious pedalling of the swan, the very illusion that China is seeking to show to the outside world disappears, because the observer regards the swan as the cause of the trouble. One way of tackling China is to call into question its public image. It is unlikely to change the direction of its policy but concern over this possibility might unsettle them to the point where they become more reasonable in a negotiation.

The question of whether this pattern of negotiating behaviour will change as a result of the changing nature of Chinese power and the consequent perception of self-image because of the massive increase in her comprehensive national power in the three decades since 1990, is a legitimate one. The style of 'wolf-warrior' diplomacy is more strident and assertive, and optically very different from the suave and subdued way of